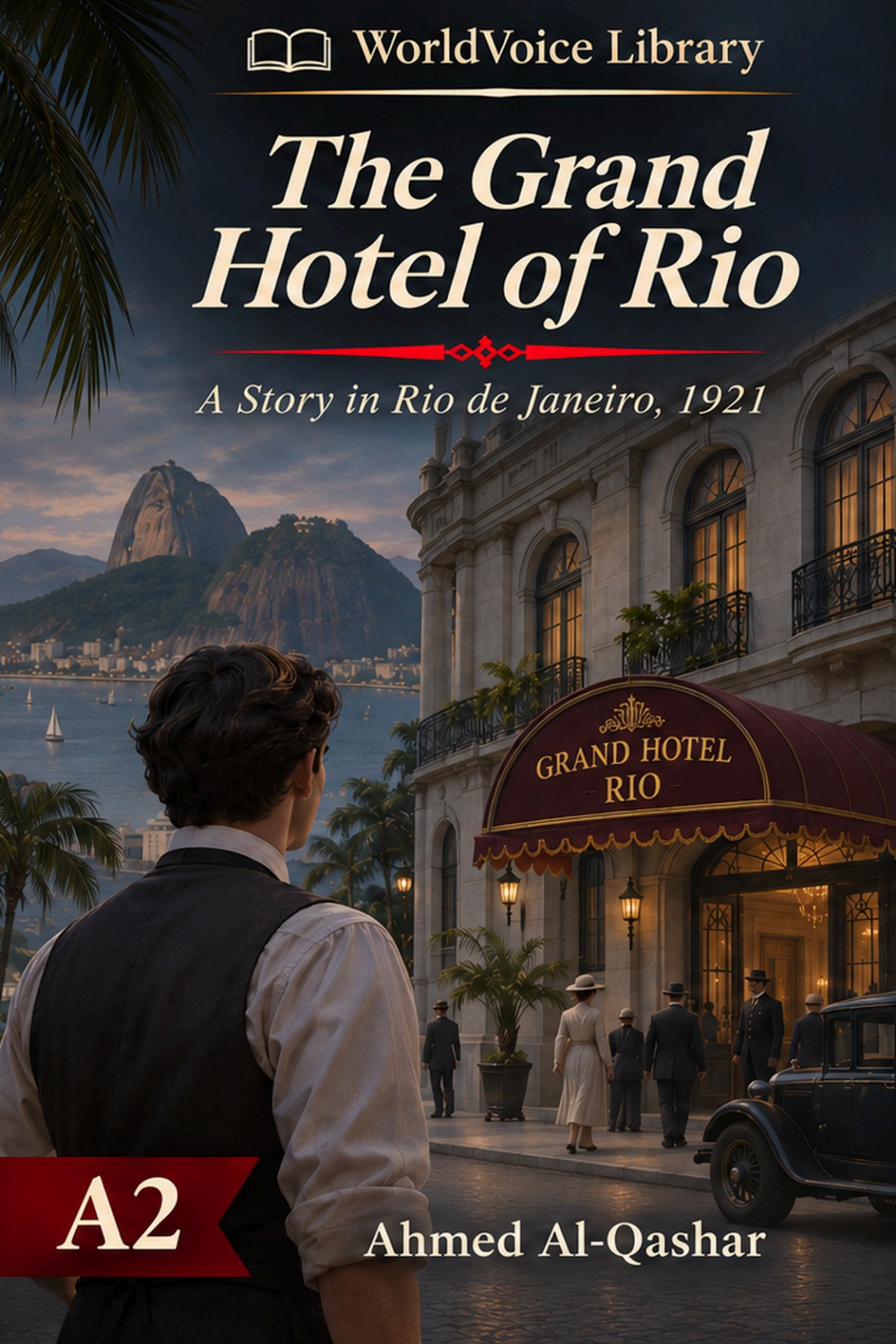

WorldVoice Library
The Grand Hotel of Rio
A Story in Rio de Janeiro, 1921
GRAND HOTEL RIO
A2
Ahmed Al-Qashar

The Grand Hotel of Rio

A Story in Rio de Janeiro, 1921

Written by
Ahmed Al-Qashar

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English Graded Readers · A2 Elementary
An original novel for language learners.

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This is an original work of fiction. The hotel and characters are invented. Historical places and city details are used as background.

A2 is the intended teaching level; independent CEFR certification has not been completed. Editorial language review is recommended before commercial publication.

The wraparound cover is the approved WorldVoice Library artwork. Its printed barcode is a design placeholder; the book does not claim a registered ISBN.

The interior illustrations have been adapted into black-ink storybook linework from artwork prepared earlier for the story.

Book size: 6 x 9 inches. Interior: black ink on white pages.

Story Introduction

One busy week. One special dinner. Many unexpected mistakes.

In Rio de Janeiro in 1921, nineteen-year-old Joaquim Alves begins his first job at the Grand Hotel of Rio. The marble floors and serious staff make him nervous, but he wants to learn.

The hotel is preparing a music dinner to help a school buy instruments for children. Before the guests arrive, two blue suitcases get confused, a dog steals a letter, a cake becomes trapped in a lift, and rain changes every plan.

Can Joaquim help the hotel give its guests a wonderful evening? This light comedy is about teamwork, kindness, and learning from mistakes.

Before You Read

1. What jobs do you think people do in a grand hotel?
2. Can a small mistake become a funny story?
3. Why might people raise money for a music school?

Characters

The people you will meet in the story



Joaquim Alves
A nineteen-year-old new porter. He is careful, kind, and sometimes nervous.



Rosa
The clever receptionist who checks names and helps the staff.



Dona Celina
The manager of the hotel. She asks everyone to tell the truth.



Bento
The experienced head porter. He seems serious but has a warm heart.



Beatriz Silva
A singer and teacher at a music school for children.



Chef Augusto
The proud hotel chef who makes an excellent orange cake.



Mrs Adelaide Faria
The woman who started the music school.



Antonio Valente
A visiting pianist with a gentle sense of humour.

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Read all seven chapters before completing the exercises at the back.

CHAPTER 1

The First Bell

On a warm Monday in June 1921, Joaquim Alves crossed a busy street in Rio de Janeiro with a clean shirt in his bag and three coins in his pocket. He was nineteen, and this was his first day at a grand hotel. He had worked in his uncle's small shop before, but he had never worked in a place with a marble floor, a brass door handle, and a man whose only job was to open the front door.

The hotel stood on a hill above a lively road. From the entrance, Joaquim could see the blue bay and the dark shape of Sugarloaf Mountain. An electric tram passed below. Its bell rang twice. A man in a white hat waved from the back of the tram, but Joaquim did not know him. Everything seemed to be moving, even the leaves of the palms above the hotel steps.



A wooden sign over the door said GRAND HOTEL OF RIO. Under it stood Bento, the head porter. Bento wore a dark coat, white gloves, and a serious face. He looked at Joaquim's shoes first. Then he looked at Joaquim.

"Are you the new boy?" he asked.

"Yes, sir. Joaquim Alves. I came early."

"You are six minutes late," Bento said.

Joaquim looked at the clock above the entrance. "My watch says eight."

"Your watch is six minutes slow. In a hotel, six minutes can become six large problems. Come inside."

Joaquim followed him into the lobby. It was cooler there. Tall windows stood above red chairs. A wide staircase went up to the guest rooms. Near the desk was a large silver bell. A woman in a dark blue dress was writing names in a book. Her hair was tied back, and she had the quick eyes of a person who noticed everything.

"This is Rosa," Bento said. "She works at the reception desk. When she asks for something, do it. When she says a guest is waiting, run. But do not run on the marble floor."

"Then how can I run?" Joaquim asked.

"That," Rosa said without looking up, "is the first question every new porter asks."

She smiled, and Joaquim felt better. Before he could smile back, a small woman with silver hair entered from an office. She carried a list in one hand and a pencil behind one ear. This was Dona Celina, the hotel manager.

"Welcome, Joaquim," she said. "I have one rule. If something goes wrong, tell the truth quickly. A small mistake can be fixed. A hidden mistake grows legs and runs through the hotel."

Joaquim promised that he understood. He did not yet know how often he would remember those words.

Dona Celina pointed to a notice on the wall. On Saturday evening the hotel would hold a music dinner. The guests would help a small music school buy instruments for children. There would be a singer, a visiting pianist, and a short speech from Mrs Adelaide Faria, the woman who had started the school. The hotel owner, Senhor Vieira, wanted every detail to be perfect.

"It is only Monday," Dona Celina said, "but Saturday comes quickly. Please treat every visitor kindly. Some are rich. Some are not. All are guests."

A motorcar stopped outside. Its driver opened the rear door, and two large suitcases appeared. The first was brown, with a silver corner. The second was blue, with a small white ribbon around its handle. A young woman stepped out carrying a violin case. She wore a plain green dress and watched the suitcases with worry.

"Beatriz Silva," Rosa whispered to Joaquim. "She is singing at the dinner."

Beatriz asked for a room and said she would return after visiting the music school. She gave Bento a small piece of paper with her room number. Another motorcar arrived at the same moment. Its driver carried a blue suitcase with a white ribbon too. This suitcase belonged to a guest named Mr Arantes, who was in Rio to repair an old theatre.

"Two blue cases," Bento said. "Do not confuse them. This one goes to room twenty-four; the other goes to room forty-two. Say the numbers to yourself."

Joaquim carried the first case to the lift. The lift was a small wooden room with a metal gate. It made a tired sound as it rose. Joaquim repeated, "Twenty-four, forty-two, twenty-four, forty-two," so often that the lift man began to laugh.

"Which number are you visiting?" the lift man asked.

Joaquim stopped. For one terrible moment he could not remember which case he held. He looked down. The white ribbon was there, but both cases had white ribbons. He knew that guessing could cause trouble. He carried the case back downstairs.

Bento stood near the desk with his arms crossed. "Why have you brought it back?"

"I don't know whose it is," Joaquim answered. "I want to check before I put it in the wrong room."

Rosa opened her book and compared the tickets. One ticket had fallen under the trolley. She found it with the tip of her shoe. The suitcase in Joaquim's hands belonged to Beatriz. The other belonged to Mr Arantes.

"Good," Dona Celina said, watching from the office door. "You lost two minutes, but you saved us a longer problem. Remember that."

Joaquim delivered both cases correctly. He came down the stairs rather than use the slow lift again. By noon he had carried six bags, found a lost hat, opened the door for seventeen people, and shown an elderly guest the way to the dining room three times. Each time the guest thanked him as if it were the first.

At lunch Rosa gave him bread, cheese, and orange juice. They sat on a bench behind the kitchen, where a warm smell of coffee came from an open window.

"Does every day feel like this?" Joaquim asked.

"No," Rosa said. "Some days are much worse."

She was joking, but Joaquim was not sure. A bell rang inside. Then another. Then someone called for a porter. Joaquim stood up so quickly that his bread fell from his hand.

"First lesson," Rosa said. "Finish your lunch before you answer a bell. People can wait twenty seconds."

Joaquim picked up his bread and laughed. This strange hotel was nothing like his uncle's shop. Yet, when he looked back through the kitchen door, he felt that he might learn to love it.

That evening he wrote a letter to his mother. He described the wide staircase and the view of the bay. He told her about the two blue suitcases and the manager's rule. He did not tell her that he had been afraid all morning. Instead he ended with one simple line: "I think I can do this work, if I listen carefully."

He folded the letter and placed it under his pillow. Through his window he could hear a distant tram bell and the gentle sound of the sea. Tomorrow, he thought, he would know the hotel a little better. He had no idea that the next guest would arrive with three different names.

CHAPTER 2

Three Names and One Room

On Tuesday morning the hotel lobby smelled of flowers and fresh floor polish. Rosa was checking the arrivals book. The pianist for Saturday's dinner was due at ten. His name was Antonio Valente, and he was famous for playing music in theatres. Dona Celina had asked for a quiet room because he said he needed to practise in peace.

"Room thirty-one," Rosa told Joaquim. "Take him there and ask if he needs water. Please do not ask him to play your favourite song."



"I don't have a favourite song," Joaquim said.

"Then do not ask him to play every song," Rosa replied.

At ten, a tall man in a grey coat walked in. He carried a long black case and an umbrella, although the sun was shining. He came to the desk and said, "Valente. I have a room."

Rosa welcomed him and gave Joaquim the key. The man smiled, thanked them, and followed Joaquim upstairs. His black case was

surprisingly light. When Joaquim asked if it held a violin, the man said no. It held a drawing stand. He was an architect named Pedro Valente.

Joaquim stopped outside room thirty-one. "Are you the pianist?"

"No," the guest answered. "My brother says I cannot sing even one correct note."

Joaquim felt his ears grow hot. He took the key back to the desk and explained. Rosa checked the book. She had entered Mr Pedro Valente's name on the wrong line. The real pianist was expected on Wednesday. Pedro needed room thirteen, not thirty-one.

"Never trust the first name alone," Rosa said. "Look at the whole name and the arrival date."

They were fixing the mistake when another guest entered. She was an older woman with a yellow hat and a small dog on a lead. The dog wore a blue ribbon and looked at everyone with great interest.

"Valente," she told Rosa. "I wrote last week."

Rosa closed her eyes for a second. "Of course, Mrs Valente. Your room is ready."

Joaquim wanted to laugh, but he kept his face serious. This was Mrs Elisa Valente, the pianist's aunt. She had not come to hear her nephew perform. She had come because she loved old hotels and planned to visit the gardens in Rio. Her dog was called Duke. Duke immediately ran toward Bento's polished shoes.

"He likes people," Mrs Valente said.

"He likes my shoes," Bento answered.

Duke pulled at a glove and ran away with it. A guest near the stairs began to laugh. Bento chased the dog around a red chair. Joaquim took a small bread roll from the breakfast trolley, held it low, and waited. Duke came straight to him. Joaquim gave Bento the glove, which was wet but still white.

"Excellent," Rosa whispered. "You have saved the hotel from a very small but very fast guest."

Dona Celina came out of her office. "Animals may stay only in the garden and the rooms on the ground floor," she said. "Mrs Valente, please remember that."

"Duke is a gentleman," Mrs Valente said.

At that moment Duke jumped on a sofa with muddy feet. Even Mrs Valente had to smile.

The rest of the morning brought a small but important problem. A newspaper reporter named Artur Barbosa arrived to ask questions about Saturday's dinner. He wanted to write about Mrs Faria's music school. He carried a notebook and a camera with a large black cover.

"Will the famous pianist play a new song?" he asked Rosa. "How many people will come? Who is paying for the dinner?"

Rosa gave him the public programme and said that some answers were not ready. Artur looked past her at the arrivals book.

"Three people named Valente?" he said. "Is the whole family coming to play?"

"No," Joaquim answered before Rosa could speak. "One is an architect, one is an aunt, and the pianist comes tomorrow."

Artur wrote quickly. "A family of artists," he said. "That is a good headline."

"But that is not what I said," Joaquim replied.

Rosa stepped forward. "Please write only what we know. Otherwise your readers will come here expecting a family concert that does not exist."

Artur stopped writing and looked at her. After a moment he smiled. "Fair enough. I will check my facts."

In the afternoon Joaquim helped carry flowers to a private sitting room. Mrs Adelaide Faria was there with two teachers from her music school. The school was in a modest building near the centre of the city. Many children practised on old instruments. Some families could not afford music lessons, so Mrs Faria helped them.

"We hope to buy six new violins," she said. "A small orchestra cannot play without instruments."

Joaquim remembered the violin case Beatriz had brought on Monday. He asked whether Beatriz worked at the school.

"Yes," Mrs Faria answered. "She teaches the younger children to sing. She will perform at our dinner."

One of the teachers, a man called Paulo, looked worried. "The printed programmes have not arrived," he said. "We need them before Saturday."

Mrs Faria put a hand on his arm. "We have four days. We can solve this."

Outside the sitting room, Joaquim found a folded sheet of paper. It was a list of guests, with names, table numbers, and a short note beside one name. He could have put it in his pocket and forgotten it. Instead he returned it to Rosa.

"Thank you," Rosa said. "This list is private. Do not leave it on a public table."

At five, Pedro Valente came down the stairs with a large drawing. He asked for a quiet place to work. Rosa gave him the small library. Mrs Valente and Duke were resting in their ground-floor room. The hotel was finally calm.

Then the telephone rang. It was the real pianist, Antonio Valente. He had changed his plans. He would arrive that evening, not Wednesday, and he wanted to practise immediately. Rosa looked at the room book. Room thirty-one was empty, but the piano in the music room had just been taken away for repairs.

"We have a pianist," she said to Joaquim, "but we do not have a piano."

"Can he practise without one?" Joaquim asked.

"Perhaps," Rosa said, "but that is a question for someone who understands music."

They told Dona Celina. She thought for a moment and said the hotel could borrow a piano from a nearby school for two days. She would ask the owner for permission. Joaquim offered to carry the music stand. He was glad that no one asked him to carry the piano.

That night, as he closed the lobby windows, Joaquim saw the three names on the arrivals board: Pedro Valente, Elisa Valente, Antonio Valente. The names looked almost the same, but the people were very

different. He wrote another line in his notebook: "A person is more than a name on a page."

CHAPTER 3

The Cake in the Lift

Wednesday began with a pleasant surprise. A piano arrived at the hotel on a wooden cart, and four strong men carried it carefully into the music room. Antonio Valente stood beside it, listening to the sound of each note. He was not tall or grand. He had a round face and kind eyes, and he spoke softly to the workers.

"Thank you," he told them. "A piano has many keys, but a good team has many hands."



Joaquim liked him immediately. He also liked the way Antonio played a bright little song after the workers left. The music travelled through the hall and reached the kitchen. Even Chef Augusto came out for a moment with flour on his hands.

"That is beautiful," Augusto said. "Now please play something about lunch. We have much work to do."

Chef Augusto was famous inside the hotel for two things: wonderful cakes and very strong opinions about soup. If the soup was too cold, he

became quiet. If the soup was too hot, he became even quieter. The kitchen staff knew that silence meant trouble.

For Saturday's dinner he planned a large orange cake. It would stand on a round table beneath a small banner that said MUSIC FOR EVERY CHILD. The cake had three layers and a decoration made from sugar. On Wednesday Augusto made a practice cake, to test the recipe and show the size to Dona Celina.

"We must take it to the second floor," he said to Joaquim. "The manager is meeting the owner in the upper dining room."

Joaquim looked at the lift. He remembered its tired sound and the time it had stopped between floors. "Is the cake safe in there?" he asked.

"It is a cake," Augusto said. "It is not a wild animal. Carry it straight and do not talk."

Bento brought a trolley. The cake rested on a wide wooden board. Joaquim and Bento moved it slowly across the lobby. Guests watched them pass. Mrs Valente looked up from her book and said, "Duke would love that."

"Please keep Duke away from it," Bento said.

The two men entered the lift with the trolley. The lift operator closed the metal gate. At first everything was fine. The cake stayed still, the trolley did not move, and Joaquim felt pleased. Then, just before the second floor, the lift stopped.

"What happened?" Bento asked.

"The old motor is tired," the operator said. "Give it a moment."

A moment became a minute. Then two minutes. There was no danger, but it was hot inside the lift. Joaquim could smell oranges and sugar. The cake looked very beautiful and very large. Bento held the trolley while the operator called for help through the gate.

"Do not touch it," Bento said when Joaquim moved his hand.

"I was only checking the board," Joaquim replied.

A small sound came from above. Water was dripping from a pipe near the lift roof. One drop fell close to the cake. Another landed on the edge of the sugar decoration.

"This is not good," Bento said.

Joaquim took off his clean jacket and held it above the cake like a little roof. His arm became tired, but the cake stayed dry. The operator found the problem, turned a handle, and the lift moved again. Everyone was safe. The jacket, however, had become wet.

When the gate opened, Dona Celina was waiting with Senhor Vieira, the hotel owner. They looked first at the cake, then at Joaquim's wet jacket.

"Why is he holding his clothes above my cake?" Senhor Vieira asked.

"Because the lift was leaking," Bento answered. "He protected the cake."

Senhor Vieira did not smile. "Then tomorrow we repair the pipe and the lift. A grand hotel should not need a young man to become a roof."

Dona Celina thanked Joaquim and sent him to find dry clothes. Augusto saw the cake and touched the sugar flower carefully. It was still perfect.

"You saved my work," the chef said. "Come to the kitchen after lunch. I have something for you."

Joaquim hoped it was a slice of cake. It was not. Augusto gave him a long list of foods and asked him to carry it to a shop near the market. The list had oranges, milk, sugar, coffee, and many other things. At the bottom the chef had written in large letters: NO PEPPER IN THE SWEET SAUCE.

Joaquim took the list, then stopped. The chef's handwriting was difficult to read. He asked Augusto to explain three words.

"Good," Augusto said. "Better to ask than to bring me ten onions when I want ten oranges."

Outside, Artur Barbosa the reporter was taking photographs of the hotel's front door. He saw Joaquim with the food list and asked whether it was the secret programme for Saturday's dinner.

"No," Joaquim said. "It is a shopping list."

"Every big event has secrets," Artur replied with a smile.

"This secret is mostly butter," Joaquim answered.

At the market he found everything on the list. He also met Lucia Mendes, a young seamstress who made dresses for several hotel guests. Lucia carried a box of blue ribbons, pins, and white cloth. She was coming to the hotel to measure the tables for the dinner.

"I know Rosa," Lucia told him. "She said you are the new porter who saved a cake."

"The story has already travelled?" Joaquim asked.

"News moves faster than the trams," Lucia said. "Especially when it is funny."

Back at the hotel, Lucia helped the staff plan the decorations. She said the tables would look better with simple white cloth and one small flower bowl on each. She was right. Too many ribbons would make the room look like a shop at carnival time. Dona Celina liked her idea.

In the afternoon the hotel owner tried the lift. It moved smoothly. The pipe had been repaired, and the lift operator showed the new safety handle. Senhor Vieira seemed pleased, but he still checked the ceiling for water.

At tea time Augusto gave Joaquim a thin slice of the practice cake. "You earned this," he said. "And you can tell me if it tastes good."

Joaquim took one bite. It was soft and sweet, with the smell of fresh oranges. "It is wonderful," he said.

"Of course it is wonderful," Augusto replied. "But thank you for saying so."

As the evening ended, Beatriz and Antonio practised their songs. Joaquim listened from outside the music room. He began to understand that a great dinner was not only about rich people and beautiful tables. Many different people worked together to make one evening feel easy.

He went to bed thinking about the lift, the cake, and the wet jacket. In his notebook he wrote, "Sometimes a mistake shows us what needs to be fixed." Then he drew a little cake beside the sentence. It was not a very good drawing, but it made him smile.

CHAPTER 4

A Speech Nobody Wrote

By Thursday, every table in the hotel had a list on it. There was a list of guests, a list of flowers, a list of songs, and a list of people who would speak at Saturday's dinner. Dona Celina kept the most important lists in her office. Rosa had copies at reception, and Senhor Vieira had made another list of things he wanted to check himself.

"We should open a hotel for lists," Joaquim told Bento. "We could give each list a room."



"Then the lists would complain about the beds," Bento answered.

Rosa was busy preparing the printed programmes. They had arrived that morning in two large boxes. Each programme named the music school and showed the order of the evening. Guests would first eat dinner, then hear Beatriz sing, then listen to Antonio play, and finally hear Mrs Faria explain the school's plans. The last page thanked everyone for helping young musicians.

"We need a short welcome speech from Senhor Vieira," Rosa said. "He wrote it yesterday, but now he cannot find it."

"Did he look in his office?" Joaquim asked.

"He looked in his office, his coat, his car, and behind the piano. He thinks the speech has walked away."

Joaquim remembered Dona Celina's rule about hidden mistakes growing legs. Perhaps, he thought, papers could grow legs too. He offered to help search. They looked under books and inside folders. They even looked behind a clock, because Senhor Vieira said he had been thinking about time when he wrote the speech.

At eleven, the hotel owner entered the lobby. He wore a dark suit and carried a folded sheet of paper. "I found it," he announced. "It was in the pocket of another coat. I will read it now, so you can tell me if it is too long."

Rosa and Joaquim stood beside the desk. Senhor Vieira opened the paper and began in a loud voice.

"Ladies and gentlemen, we are pleased to welcome you to this fine hotel. Tonight we celebrate the joy of music and the hope of children. First, wash three large oranges. Then cut them into thin pieces."

He stopped. Rosa pressed her lips together. Joaquim looked down at his shoes. Senhor Vieira read the next line silently. "Add sugar and warm milk," he said, almost in a whisper.

"That is the chef's recipe," Joaquim said gently.

The owner stared at the paper. A smile slowly crossed his face. "Then this will be the sweetest speech I have ever made," he said.

Everyone laughed, even Bento, who had entered just in time to hear the last sentence. The owner folded the recipe and returned it to the kitchen. He still needed a speech, but now the problem felt smaller.

Mrs Adelaide Faria came to the hotel after lunch. She had visited her school that morning and had brought three children with her. The children were going to sing a short welcome song at the dinner. Their names were Ana, Miguel, and Luis. They stood close together and looked at the high ceiling with wide eyes.

"This place is bigger than our school," Miguel said.

"But our school has better windows," Ana replied. "We can open all of them."

Beatriz showed the children the music room and let them touch the piano gently. Antonio played three simple notes, and the children sang them back. Joaquim watched from the door. The children were nervous at first, but their voices became stronger as Beatriz smiled at them.

"They will be wonderful," Joaquim said to Mrs Faria.

"They will try," she answered. "That matters more than being perfect."

Mrs Faria told him about a girl at the school who had practised every day on a broken violin. She wanted to learn, but there was not enough money for a new instrument. The dinner would help children like her. Joaquim suddenly understood why the staff had worked so hard all week. The flowers and cake were pleasant, but the real reason for the evening was outside the hotel.

In the afternoon an envelope arrived at reception. It was marked FOR MRS FARIA. Rosa handed it to Joaquim and asked him to carry it to the sitting room. Before he reached the door, Mrs Valente's dog came

running toward him. Duke liked envelopes almost as much as he liked gloves. He jumped, caught a corner of the paper in his mouth, and pulled.

"Duke!" Mrs Valente cried from the hall. "That is not your letter!"

Joaquim did not pull back hard. He knelt, spoke softly, and offered the dog a wooden toy from the basket near the garden door. Duke let go of the envelope. It was wet and had a small hole, but the address was still clear.

"I am very sorry," Mrs Valente said. "He thinks every paper is an invitation to play."

Joaquim gave the letter to Mrs Faria and explained what had happened. The letter was from a teacher who could not come on Saturday. It also contained a short song for the children. The words were easy to read, but a small part of the music page had been torn.

"Can the song be saved?" Joaquim asked.

Antonio looked at the page. "Most of it is here," he said. "I can write the missing notes. The teacher has shown me this song before."

He copied the music carefully. Beatriz helped the children sing the new copy. They practised the last line again and again. When they finished, Ana gave Joaquim a small bow and thanked him for saving the letter.

"I did not save the music," he said. "I only helped Duke change his mind."

"That is sometimes a great talent," Beatriz replied.

Later, Artur Barbosa came to photograph the children. He asked if the hotel would tell him how much money the dinner hoped to raise. Mrs

Faria answered that they had a goal, but she did not want people to think it was a competition. Every gift would help, even a small one.

"Then the story is not about rich people at a beautiful hotel," Artur said, closing his notebook. "It is about children learning to play."

"Now you understand," Rosa told him.

At five, Senhor Vieira asked Joaquim to bring him some clean paper. The owner sat at a desk near the garden and began to write a new speech. This time he did not start with the hotel's fine chairs or large windows. He wrote about the first music teacher he had known as a child, a woman who had shown him that music belonged to everyone.

When he finished, he read the speech aloud to Dona Celina. It lasted only two minutes. She listened without moving her pencil. Then she said, "That is the right speech."

"Are you certain?" the owner asked.

"Yes. And I am happy that it contains no instructions about oranges."

They both laughed. Joaquim put the clean copy in a folder marked SATURDAY. On the folder he wrote in clear letters, SPEECH - NOT RECIPE. It was a small joke, but it helped everyone remember which paper was important.

As darkness came, music floated through the hotel. The children had gone home, and the guests were taking dinner. Joaquim stood beside the lobby desk, watching people move through the doors. On Monday he had been afraid to speak. Now he knew nearly every member of the staff and had learned to ask questions before a mistake became trouble.

He opened his notebook and wrote, "A good speech says something true." Below that he added, "And a good dog should stay away from

letters." This second line made him laugh so loudly that Bento turned around and asked what was funny. Joaquim showed him the page. Bento smiled and went back to his work without saying a word.

CHAPTER 5

Rain Over the Terrace

Friday morning arrived under dark clouds. From the hotel windows, the bay looked grey. The wind moved the palm leaves and pushed rain against the glass. Dona Celina stood on the terrace with Rosa, looking at the long tables that had been prepared for Saturday's dinner.

"We may need another room," Rosa said.



"The weather report says rain tonight and perhaps tomorrow," Dona Celina answered. "A dinner outdoors would be beautiful, but wet guests are not happy guests."

The terrace was the hotel's proudest place. It looked over the city, and on clear evenings guests could see boats with little lights moving across the water. Senhor Vieira loved it. He had promised everyone that the music dinner would be held there. Moving indoors would disappoint him.

At breakfast, he came to the terrace and looked at the sky. "The rain will stop," he said with great confidence. "It always does."

"Yes," Dona Celina agreed. "But we need to know when."

For several hours the staff watched the clouds. Lucia arrived with the table cloths, and Bento carried the flower bowls upstairs. Beatriz came to practise, keeping her violin case under her coat. The reporter Artur visited again, hoping to take pictures of the tables before the guests arrived.

At noon the rain began. It came softly for ten minutes, then heavily for twenty. Water ran along the terrace steps. A flower bowl filled like a little pond. Joaquim moved the programmes away from the open doors and covered the piano in the music room. There was no danger, but the hotel seemed to be working against the weather.

"We cannot place sixty people on this terrace," Rosa said.

Dona Celina nodded. "We move the dinner to the library hall. Tell the owner. I will speak to the chef."

The library hall was large, with tall windows, shelves of books, and a wooden floor. It had space for the tables, but it was usually quiet. Guests came there to read or write letters. On Saturday it would need to become a dining room, a music room, and a place for speeches.

Senhor Vieira did not like the idea at first. "The terrace is the heart of this hotel," he said. "People came because of the view."

"And they will remember the evening because of the music," Dona Celina answered. "If they are dry, they can enjoy it."

The owner stood by the window and watched the rain. Then he nodded. "Very well. Move the dinner indoors. Do it properly."

They began at once. Bento marked the floor with pieces of paper to show where the tables could stand. Lucia checked the windows and

measured the space between the chairs. Rosa moved the guest list and table numbers. Augusto sent two cooks to help carry dishes from the kitchen. Joaquim brought fresh water to everyone.

The first plan did not work. One table blocked the entrance. Another was too close to the piano, and the pianist could not sit down. A third stood under a shelf from which someone might pull a heavy book. They moved the furniture again.

"If the guests arrive now," Bento said, "they will think we are opening a furniture shop."

"Then we must give them excellent service," Joaquim replied. "Perhaps they will buy a chair."

Lucia laughed. She took a piece of chalk and drew a better plan on a large sheet of paper. The tables stood in two long lines, with a clear path to the doors and space at the front for the children and musicians. There was also a small place for the cake away from the windows.

"The room is not large," Lucia said, "but we can make it comfortable."

Her idea worked. By four o'clock, the furniture stood in the right places. The floor was clean and the white cloths were smooth. The room looked warm despite the rain outside. Dona Celina thanked Lucia, who only smiled and asked for another box of pins.

While they were working, a little problem grew in the kitchen. Augusto had planned to bring hot dishes up the outdoor service steps. Those steps were now wet and slippery. The new route through the main corridor was safer, but it passed near the music room and would disturb the children while they sang.

Joaquim knew a smaller passage behind the library. He had found it while looking for a lost umbrella on Tuesday. The passage led to a side door near the kitchen. He showed it to Bento and Augusto.

"The dishes can come this way," he said. "The cooks will not cross the music area."

Augusto walked through the passage and checked the floor. "It is narrow," he said, "but with one trolley at a time it will work."

Dona Celina made a rule: one trolley in the passage, one person to guide it, and no heavy dishes carried at the same time. Joaquim offered to stand at the far door and help the cooks turn the trolley safely.

At six, Antonio came to check the piano. It had been moved next to a window. He played a few notes and said the sound was good. Beatriz stood beside him and tried a song. The shelves seemed to hold the music gently. In the big terrace the notes would have gone into the open air; here they stayed with the listeners.

"This is a fine room," Antonio said. "Perhaps better than the terrace for music."

Rosa looked delighted. "Please tell Senhor Vieira that. He needs to hear it from a musician."

In the evening there was a short power problem in one part of the hotel. A lamp in the library went out, then came on again. The electrician checked the wires and said a loose connection needed repair. He finished the work before the staff left. Dona Celina had extra lamps placed where people could find them if needed, but she did not fill the room with bright lights. A calm room was better for listening.

Joaquim returned to the terrace before bed. The rain had become light. Far below, a tram moved along the road, and its bell was almost lost in the sound of the sea. The chairs were empty. Water fell from the table edges in small lines.

He was sad for a moment. The outdoor dinner would have been beautiful. Then he remembered the children's song, and the warm library, and Lucia's simple plan. A good evening, he thought, did not need perfect weather. It needed people who were willing to help.

He wrote in his notebook, "When the first plan fails, make a better one together." Then he closed the window and went to sleep. Saturday was waiting, and he hoped the weather would not bring any more surprises.

CHAPTER 6

The Blue Ribbon

Saturday began with clear air but a wet street. The storm had passed during the night. Small clouds still moved above the hills, and the hotel garden smelled of fresh earth. Joaquim came early, this time with his watch correctly set. Bento checked the time and said nothing, which was almost a compliment.

In the library the staff had worked late the night before. The chairs stood in neat lines. Each table held a white cloth, a small flower bowl, and a card with a number. The programmes lay beside the plates. The piano waited at the front of the room. It was quiet and beautiful.



Dona Celina gave everyone a final job. Rosa would welcome guests and check names. Bento would lead people to their tables. Augusto would direct the food. Lucia would watch the decorations. Joaquim would take messages between the kitchen and library and help Beatriz with the children's arrival.

"One more thing," Dona Celina said. "If there is a problem, tell us. We have time to solve it only if we know about it."

At ten, Beatriz came down from her room looking worried. She carried a blue suitcase with a white ribbon.

"Joaquim," she said, "this is not mine."

He looked at the case. It was the same size as hers, and the ribbon was the same colour. He had been certain that he had sent both cases to the correct rooms on Monday. How could the case be wrong now?

Beatriz opened it in a small sitting room. Inside were a ruler, several drawing tools, a dark jacket, and rolls of paper. There was no concert dress, no music folder, and no pair of comfortable shoes. Beatriz stared at the tools and began to laugh in disbelief.

"I cannot sing in a ruler," she said. "My dress was in this suitcase."

Joaquim felt his stomach turn. "I checked the labels," he said. "I truly did."

"I believe you," Beatriz answered. "But someone has given me the wrong case since then."

They told Rosa. She found the luggage book and compared Monday's entries with the room numbers. The labels had been correct at reception. On Tuesday a worker had moved several cases while cleaning the luggage room. Both blue cases had been placed together, and the loose paper labels had fallen off. Someone had then sent the cases upstairs by their ribbons alone.

"We need to speak to Mr Arantes," Rosa said. "He may have Beatriz's things."

Mr Arantes, the theatre architect, was having breakfast in the garden. When he heard the story, he stood up and shook his head.

"My blue suitcase is in my room," he said, "but I have not opened it. I came here to make drawings and carried everything I needed in my black case."

They went to room forty-two, where his suitcase rested near the wardrobe. It had the same white ribbon. Inside were a green concert dress, two pairs of shoes, sheet music, and a small packet of letters. Beatriz gave a long, happy breath.

"There they are," she said. "I thought my whole evening was lost."

"And I thought I had packed some very unusual drawing tools," Mr Arantes replied. "Now I understand the extra weight."

Rosa wrote new cards for the cases and tied them firmly to the handles. The guests exchanged their belongings. There was no anger. Mr Arantes even offered to help carry the music folder to the library.

"A label should tell you whose case it is," he said. "A white ribbon only tells you that somebody likes white ribbons."

Joaquim repeated the sentence to Bento. The older porter looked serious for a moment, then said, "Good advice from a man who did not open his suitcase for five days."

At noon Mrs Faria arrived with the three children. Ana carried her music in a blue folder; Miguel had a small drum; Luis held a flower for the singer. They were excited about the evening but worried that they might forget their words. Beatriz told them that even adults sometimes forgot words.

"What do you do when that happens?" Ana asked.

"You breathe," Beatriz said. "You look at your friends. Then you begin again."

Joaquim brought them water and showed them the little garden behind the library. They walked slowly among the plants to calm their nerves. Luis asked if the hotel owner would be there. Joaquim said yes. Miguel asked if he was very rich. Joaquim answered that he owned a hotel, but also that he had once been a schoolboy who needed help with music.

"Then perhaps he is not so frightening," Ana said.

By three the cooks were preparing the first dishes. The orange cake stood safely in the cold room. Augusto checked it and gave the top layer one final touch. He had made tiny sugar flowers, each no larger than a coin. There was not one pepper in the sweet sauce.

Artur Barbosa arrived with his camera, and Mrs Valente came to watch the decorations with Duke on a short lead. Rosa stopped the dog at the library door. "Duke cannot attend the dinner," she said firmly.

"He is well behaved," Mrs Valente argued.

Just then Duke pulled toward the cake trolley. Mrs Valente changed her mind. "Perhaps he will be happier in the garden," she said.

At four, the pianist began to practise quietly. Beatriz put on her green dress and tested the room with a single note. It sounded warm and clear. Mr Arantes checked the position of the music stand. Lucia fixed a loose ribbon near the door, then took it away because the room looked better without it.

Joaquim stepped back to look. No one would guess how many problems had come before this peaceful hour. The room had been moved, the lift had been repaired, the cases had been exchanged, and

the speech had been written again. The staff were tired, but they smiled at one another.

Then the head waiter came running from the kitchen. He carried a list in his hand and looked pale.

"There is a mistake in the dinner orders," he told Augusto. "We have thirty fish plates and thirty chicken plates. But the new list says forty guests want fish."

Augusto put down his spoon. "Who changed the numbers?"

No one knew. Rosa checked the first list. Several guests had changed their meals during the week, but the changes were written in different places. One sheet showed old numbers, another new ones. The food was ready, and the doors would open in two hours.

"We cannot make ten new fish dishes at once," the chef said.

Dona Celina looked at the lists. "Then we need to know which guests have a strong reason to choose fish and who can accept either meal. We must ask politely, before dinner."

Joaquim offered to help. He took clean paper to Rosa, and they prepared a small question for each table. When the guests arrived, the reception staff would check their choices. No one would be asked to change a meal because it was easier for the kitchen. But those who did not mind could help.

"You have saved us again," Augusto told Joaquim.

"Not yet," Joaquim answered. "First we have to ask the guests."

At six the first visitors came through the front door. The hotel bells rang softly. A line of hats and coats filled the lobby. Joaquim

straightened his jacket and took his place beside Rosa. The dinner had begun. The last surprise of the week was still waiting in the library.

CHAPTER 7

The Night Everyone Remembered

By half past six the Grand Hotel of Rio was full of voices. Guests talked in the lobby while they waited to enter the library. Some had come in motorcars, others by tram, and a few on foot. Outside, the street was cool after the rain. Inside, the staff moved calmly from one person to another.

Rosa checked each name and asked about dinner choices. Most guests remembered what they had ordered. A few did not. One older man said he had ordered fish, but his wife said he had asked for chicken. He thought about it and smiled.



"If it is good," he said, "I will eat either."

Several guests were happy to choose chicken, and the kitchen had enough fish for those who wanted it. The food problem became smaller with every table. Augusto received the final numbers and nodded.

"I can work with these," he said. "Now let me cook."

Joaquim guided an elderly couple to their seats. He carried a chair for a woman who walked with a stick. He helped Mr Arantes find his table and told Mrs Valente that Duke was resting safely in her room. The guests thanked him, and he answered without feeling afraid. He had learned more in one week than he had expected to learn in a month.

At seven the library doors opened. The room looked beautiful. The small flower bowls stood on the white cloths. Light from simple lamps touched the bookshelves. The piano waited near the front window. The music school children stood beside Beatriz, dressed neatly but without expensive clothes.

Senhor Vieira entered and smiled at Dona Celina. "This room is better than I thought," he admitted.

"We had good help," she said.

Dinner began. The food arrived through the narrow passage, one trolley at a time. Joaquim held the side door and helped the cooks turn the corner. The soup was hot, the fish was good, and the chicken smelled wonderful. Augusto stood in the kitchen, listening to the sounds from the library.

"They are eating," he said to his cooks. "That is a pleasant sound."

When the plates were cleared, Senhor Vieira stood to give his welcome speech. He carried the correct paper this time. He spoke about the music school, about the teacher who had encouraged him as a boy, and about the chance every child deserved. He did not mention the hotel furniture. He did not mention oranges. He thanked the guests for coming, and his words were simple and warm.

Then Ana, Miguel, and Luis walked to the front of the room. Beatriz nodded to Antonio, who played the first notes. The children began to

sing. At first their voices were quiet, but then Ana looked at her friends, and the sound grew stronger. Some guests smiled. Mrs Faria sat very still, with her hands folded.

Halfway through the song, Miguel forgot one line. He stopped, and the other two children stopped with him. For a moment the room was silent. Joaquim felt his heart beat fast. He knew the children had practised this part many times. He wanted to help, but he did not know how.

Beatriz smiled at them and sang the first word softly. Ana took a breath and continued. Miguel joined her, then Luis. The song began again, and this time they finished it together. The guests clapped warmly, not because it had been perfect, but because the children had been brave.

"They remembered," Rosa whispered beside Joaquim.

"They remembered how to begin again," he answered.

Antonio played a joyful piece on the piano. Beatriz sang a song about the sea, and the room became quiet enough to hear the last note fade. Even Bento stopped near the door and listened. He did not look serious at all.

After the music, Mrs Faria spoke for a few minutes. She told the guests about the small school, the old instruments, and the children who came to practise after their lessons. She explained that the money from the evening would buy new violins, repair the piano at the school, and help pay for lessons. She did not promise that every child would become famous. She promised only that every child would have a chance to learn.

A small wooden box stood on a table for gifts. Some guests placed money inside. Others wrote their names on cards to offer help later.

Pedro Valente, the architect, said he could examine the school's old roof without charge. Lucia offered to sew curtains for the music room. Artur Barbosa promised to write an article about the children and their teachers.

"I wanted a story about a grand hotel," Artur admitted. "I found a better one."

Before the cake arrived, there was one last moment of confusion. A waiter came to the kitchen door and said that the lights over the cake table were too bright. They were making the sugar flowers look almost white. Augusto became worried. He wanted the guests to see the cake properly, but he did not want the decoration to melt near a warm lamp.

Joaquim suggested moving the cake table a little farther from the light. Lucia helped him find a clear place beside the bookcase. They moved the table carefully, without disturbing the guests. The cake looked beautiful in the softer light.

"You have made my cake look like a painting," Augusto said.

"This time," Joaquim replied, "I did not have to hold my jacket over it."

The chef laughed so loudly that a guest looked toward the door. Then Augusto returned to the kitchen and brought out the cake himself. Everyone clapped when they saw it. He cut the first slice for Mrs Faria and gave the next three small pieces to the children. Duke was nowhere near the table, which everyone considered another success.

At the end of the evening Dona Celina opened the gift box with Mrs Faria and Senhor Vieira. They counted the money carefully and compared it with the cards. There was enough to buy the six violins the school needed. There was also a little extra money for repairs. Mrs Faria put a hand over her mouth and looked at the children.

"We did it," she said softly.

"You did it," Senhor Vieira answered. "The children gave us the reason. We only opened the doors."

As the guests prepared to leave, Joaquim helped with coats and hats. Mrs Valente thanked him for being kind to Duke. Pedro Valente said that the library room was very well arranged. Artur asked Joaquim for his name so that he could thank the hotel staff in his article. Joaquim told him the names of Rosa, Bento, Lucia, Augusto, and Dona Celina as well.

"That is a long list," Artur said.

"It was a long week," Joaquim replied.

When the last guest had gone, the staff gathered in the quiet library. The flowers were tired, the plates were empty, and the piano was closed. Everyone looked exhausted. Dona Celina thanked each person in turn. Then she called Joaquim forward.

"You came here on Monday," she said, "and you were afraid to make a mistake. This week you asked questions, told the truth, and helped other people. You are still learning, but you have become part of our team."

Senhor Vieira handed him a small new badge for his coat. It said ASSISTANT PORTER. Joaquim read the words twice.

"Does this mean I am no longer the new boy?" he asked.

"You will always be new at something," Bento said. "That is how people learn. But tomorrow you can help the next new boy."

Rosa clapped first. Then everyone joined her. Joaquim's face grew warm, but this time it was not from embarrassment. He felt proud and grateful. He thought of his mother, his uncle's small shop, and the first six minutes of Monday morning.

Near midnight he stood outside the hotel doors. The street was quiet. Far below, the bay reflected a few lights, and the hills were dark against the sky. The grand hotel no longer seemed too large for him. It seemed full of people he knew.

He took out his little notebook and read the lessons he had written during the week: listen before you act, check a name carefully, ask for help, tell the truth, change a plan when needed, and remember the reason for your work. On a new page he wrote one more sentence: "A grand evening is made by many ordinary acts of care."

Then he closed the notebook. Tomorrow the hotel would open its doors again. There would be guests, bells, luggage, questions, and perhaps another dog. There would certainly be a new mistake to solve. Joaquim smiled and went inside, ready to begin.

Vocabulary (40 Words)

Useful words from the story, with simple meanings and examples

Word	Meaning	Example
arrival	the time when someone reaches a place	His arrival was early.
architect	a person who designs buildings	Pedro was an architect.
banner	a long sign made of cloth or paper	The banner was above the cake.
bell	a small object that makes a ringing sound	The hotel bell rang.
brave	ready to do something even when afraid	The children were brave.
case	a box or bag for carrying things	The blue case was heavy.
celebrate	to do something special for a happy event	They celebrate music.
chef	a skilled cook	Augusto was the chef.
choice	something that you decide	Each guest made a choice.
clap	to hit your hands together to show pleasure	The guests clap after the song.
confuse	to make someone unsure	The same names confuse Joaquim.
corridor	a long passage inside a building	They walked along the corridor.
decorate	to make a place look attractive	Lucia helped decorate the room.

Word	Meaning	Example
deliver	to take something to a person or place	Joaquim delivers the cases.
dinner	a meal in the evening	The dinner was on Saturday.
envelope	paper cover for a letter	Duke caught the envelope.
folder	a cover that holds papers	Rosa used a blue folder.
guest	a person staying at a hotel	The guest thanked him.
instrument	an object used to make music	The school needed instruments.
invitation	a message asking someone to come	Guests received an invitation.
jacket	clothing worn over a shirt	His jacket became wet.
kind	good and helpful to others	Beatriz was kind.
label	a tag that tells you what something is	The label fell off the case.
lift	a small room that carries people between floors	The lift stopped.
list	names or things written one after another	Rosa checked the list.
lobby	the first large room inside a hotel	The lobby was cool.
manager	the person who runs a place of work	Celina was the manager.
mistake	something that is done incorrectly	He corrected the mistake.
musician	a person who plays or makes music	Antonio was a musician.
owner	a person to whom something belongs	Vieira was the hotel owner.

Word	Meaning	Example
porter	a worker who carries bags for guests	Joaquim worked as a porter.
practice	to repeat an action to improve	The children practice singing.
programme	a list of what will happen at an event	The programme showed the songs.
reception	the place where guests are welcomed	Rosa worked at reception.
repair	to make a broken thing work again	They repaired the lift.
ribbon	a narrow strip of cloth	The case had a white ribbon.
speech	words spoken to a group of people	Vieira wrote a speech.
terrace	a flat area outside a building	Rain fell on the terrace.
trolley	a small cart for moving things	Bento pushed the trolley.
volunteer	to offer help without being asked	Lucia volunteered to help.

Reading Comprehension

Choose the best answer: A, B, or C.

1. Why did Joaquim come to the hotel?

A. To begin work B. To perform music C. To buy a motorcar

2. Who showed Joaquim the hotel rules?

A. Artur B. Dona Celina C. Duke

3. What made the blue cases difficult to identify?

A. They had the same ribbons B. They were broken C. They were empty

4. Who was the receptionist?

A. Rosa B. Lucia C. Ana

5. How many people named Valente were expected?

A. One B. Two C. Three

6. What did Duke take?

A. A glove and a letter B. A piano C. A cake

7. Why was the music dinner organised?

A. To open a new road B. To help a music school C. To celebrate a wedding

8. What happened to the lift?

A. It became stuck B. It fell C. It was sold

9. How did Joaquim protect the cake?

A. With his jacket B. With a hat C. With a book

10. Which paper did the owner read by mistake?

A. A shopping recipe B. A bill C. A map

11. Why did the dinner move to the library?

A. A guest asked for it B. It rained C. The piano was too old

12. Who drew the better table plan?

A. Lucia B. Duke C. Artur

13. What did Mr Arantes find in his case?

A. A green dress B. Gold coins C. A camera

14. Who wrote about the event in a newspaper?

A. Artur B. Bento C. Luis

15. What did Miguel forget during the song?

A. His shoes B. One line C. His name

16. What did Mrs Faria hope to buy?

A. Six violins B. A hotel C. Ten motorcars

17. What new position did Joaquim receive?

A. Manager B. Chef C. Assistant porter

18. What is the central lesson of the story?

A. Help one another and tell the truth B. Never ask questions C. All mistakes are terrible

Short Answer Questions

Write one or two sentences for each question.

1. Why was Joaquim nervous on Monday?

_____

2. Why did he bring the first blue case back to reception?

_____

3. What did Rosa teach him about the Valente names?

_____

4. Why did Augusto value the practice cake?

_____

5. How did the dog cause trouble with the music letter?

_____

6. Why was the library safer than the terrace on Friday?

_____

7. How did Lucia help with the dinner?

_____

8. What made the blue cases confusing again on Saturday?

_____

9. How did Beatriz help the children when they stopped singing?

_____

10. What did Joaquim learn about being part of a team?

_____

Think · Speak · Write

Talk about the ideas, then write in your own words.

1. Is it better to ask a question or to guess? Give an example.

_____

2. Why do many people have to work together in a hotel?

_____

3. What can we do when a plan changes because of bad weather?

_____

4. What makes a person a good leader?

_____

5. Have you ever helped someone solve a difficult problem?

_____

6. Why should every child have a chance to learn music or art?

_____

Writing Task

Write 100-120 words about a day when something went wrong but your friends or family helped you. Describe the problem, your feelings, and the solution.

Title: _____

_____

Language Practice

Past tense, comparisons, and useful hotel language

1. Joaquim ___ at eight.

A. arrived B. arrive C. arriving

2. Rosa ___ names in a book.

A. write B. wrote C. writing

3. The two cases ___ similar.

A. was B. were C. is

4. The children ___ a song at the dinner.

A. sing B. sang C. sings

5. The rain was ___ than before.

A. heavy B. heavier C. heaviest

6. The music room was ___ the library.

A. near B. under than C. rather

7. Dona Celina asked him ___ the truth.

A. tell B. to tell C. telling

8. He did not ___ the letter.

A. lose B. lost C. losing

9. The guests ___ while the music was playing.

A. listened B. listens C. listen

10. They needed ___ new violins.

A. buy B. to buy C. bought

11. Joaquim was ___ than he felt on Monday.

A. confident B. more confident C. most confident

12. The lift ___ for two minutes.

A. stopped B. stop C. stopping

Useful Phrases

• Could you help me with this case?

• May I check your room number?

• I am sorry for the mistake.

• Let me find the correct information.

• We have changed the dinner room because of the weather.

• Thank you for waiting.

Final Test

24 questions · Vocabulary, Grammar, and Story

1. A porter usually carries __ .
A. bags B. songs C. food recipes

2. A room __ tells you where a guest stays.
A. label B. number C. ribbon

3. The person who runs the hotel is the __ .
A. manager B. violinist C. reporter

4. A __ is used to carry food to a table.
A. trolley B. ribbon C. speech

5. A __ makes music.
A. musician B. guest C. architect

6. A __ is given to a group of listeners.
A. speech B. jacket C. case

7. A __ is a place where guests enter a hotel.
A. lobby B. lift C. terrace

8. To __ means to make something work again.
A. repair B. remember C. confuse

9. Yesterday Rosa __ the guest list.
A. checks B. checked C. check

10. The children __ happy after singing.
A. was B. is C. were

11. Joaquim __ not know which case he held.
A. did B. does C. do

12. They moved the dinner __ it was raining.
A. because B. but C. than

13. Beatriz was __ when she found her dress.

A. happier B. happiness C. happily

14. The guests __ as the pianist played.
A. listening B. listened C. listen

15. He asked Rosa __ the number.
A. check B. to check C. checked

16. They __ the table by the window.
A. put B. puts C. putting

17. Where does the story take place?
A. Lisbon B. Rio de Janeiro C. London

18. In which year does it take place?
A. 1921 B. 1871 C. 1784

19. What was the practice cake made with?
A. Oranges B. Lemons C. Apples

20. Who was Mrs Valente?
A. The pianist's aunt B. The hotel owner C. The chef

21. Why was the music letter damaged?
A. Rain fell on it B. Duke took it C. It was burnt

22. Where was the dinner finally held?
A. The library B. The terrace C. The street

23. What did the music school need?
A. Six violins B. A new motorcar C. A hotel lift

24. What was Joaquim□s new role?
A. Head chef B. Assistant porter C. Famous singer

Score: _____ / 24

Answer Key

Check your answers only after completing the exercises.

Reading Comprehension

1. A 2. B 3. A 4. A 5. C 6. A 7. B 8. A 9. A

10. A 11. B 12. A 13. A 14. A 15. B 16. A 17. C 18. A

Language Practice

1. A 2. B 3. B 4. B 5. B 6. A 7. B 8. A 9. A 10. B 11. B 12. A

Final Test

1. A 2. B 3. A 4. A 5. A 6. A 7. A 8. A

9. B 10. C 11. A 12. A 13. A 14. B 15. B 16. A

17. B 18. A 19. A 20. A 21. B 22. A 23. A 24. B

Short Answer Questions – Sample Answers

1. He wanted to do his first job correctly and had never worked in a grand hotel.

2. Both blue cases had white ribbons, so he asked Rosa to check the labels.

3. She taught him to check full names and arrival dates, not only the first name.

4. The chef wanted to test the recipe and show the cake to the manager.

5. Duke pulled the envelope and tore part of the paper.

6. Rain made the terrace wet, so the library was a safer place for the guests.

7. She made a simple plan for the tables and helped with decorations.

8. The paper labels fell off when a worker moved the cases.

9. She helped them take a breath and start the song again.

10. He learned to ask questions, tell the truth, and work with others.

Discussion and writing questions have more than one good answer.

WorldVoice Library

The Grand Hotel of Rio

This graded reader includes:

- A fun and engaging story
- Seven illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level
A2
Elementary



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